

ANI

SECURITY CHECK J&K L-G Manoj Sinha at a meeting with army chief Gen. Upendra Dwivedi and others, Jammu, Jul. 20

central rule and the stifling security blanket caused a void, leaving people scrambling to deal with basic issues. Many see this vacuum as the reason for the lack of integration with security forces in Jammu, resulting in the lack of 'humint' (human intelligence) flow on the presence of terrorists in the high ranges.

A senior army commander who had served in the region at the peak of militancy in 2000 says the terrain is such that local support who can act as "the eyes and ears is crucial for both sides". He lists a series of unpopular decisions, including reservation for Paharis, the eviction of the Gujjars and Bakerwals (shepherd communities) from the forests and the BJP's support for the convicts in the 2018 Kathua minor girl rape-murder case, for alienating the local population. "The concerted campaign against the minorities has affected the people in Jammu. Otherwise, they (the Bakerwals/ Gujjars) were the army's first line of defence since 1947," he says.

rorists, split in small units, operating in Rajouri, Poonch, Reasi, Kishtwar, Doda, Bhaderwah and Kathua. Former J&K DGP Shesh Paul Vaid claims that Pakistani army commanders are behind the recent attacks in the Jammu region. "It's an act of war and India needs to respond accordingly," says the ex-DGP.

A section of army/ police officials also claim the attacks bear the footprint of the Jaish-e-Mohammed (JeM), who carried out the 2001 attack on the Indian Parliament. With Jaish and the Lashkar-e-Taiba now on the global terror list, their handlers have adopted shadow names to avoid scrutiny after August 2019. New fronts like the Peoples Anti-Fascist Force (PAFF) and Kashmir Tigers have claimed responsibility for the attacks in Jammu.

A senior defence official in Jammu says these new fronts emerged with Lashkar setting up the TRF (The Resistance Front) peddling propaganda on social media. In some cases, the terrorists have also released videos of attacks. "But now, the TRF has gone silent and these others have come forward with attack claims and propaganda videos, much of it with morphed videos and photos. These new front names are meant to show that they are indigenous *tanzeems* (organisations)," he says.

The shift, says a senior police official, is to exploit communal tensions and create discord in Jammu ahead of the assembly election in the UTs (the Supreme Court has set a deadline of September 30 for it). He cites the July 9 attack in Reasi on a bus carrying pilgrims from the Shiv Khori temple in which nine Hindu pilgrims were killed as an example. "Pakistan wants to show that they are also stakeholders," he says.

"WE WILL NOT ALLOW THE REVIVAL OF TERRORISM IN JAMMU AT ANY COST.... WE'LL ADOPT THE KASHMIR MODEL TO WIPE IT OUT"

MANOJ SINHA, *J&K Lt Governor*

THE PUSHBACK

Amid these challenges, defence experts suggest multiple options to fix the problem. Lt Gen. Hooda, who directed India's surgical strike inside Pakistan in September 2016, suggests a two-pronged strategy—take credible action against Pakistan while also devising a counterinsurgency strategy against the terrorists. "Some pressure needs to be put on Pakistan, be it revisiting the ceasefire (along the LoC) or carrying out overt/ covert actions against it. Whatever the government decides, the action must be credible. We did strikes in the past and they had some impact, but if deterrence is weakening, it must be communicated to Pakistan that the cost will increase."

On the ground, besides the redeployment of forces, the government has reactivated over 27,000 Village Defence Guards (VDGs). In Poonch, there has been a breakthrough with the arrest of a man from Kashmir. Mohammed Khalil Lone is from north Kashmir's Bandipora, and was nabbed in a joint operation by the army's 39 RR and the J&K police and is reportedly an overground worker of the Hizbul Mujahideen. He had come to the border district to collect an arms shipment. The news on the VDGs, though, elicited mixed reactions from the local population. The civil militia had helped the forces wipe out militancy from the mountainous region but also many allegations of torture and abuse. At a time when 'humint' (human intelligence) is at a low in Jammu, the administration and the security forces will have to tread lightly and not alienate the local population any further. ■

with Pradip R. Sagar